

FREE SAMPLE

Hognose Snake Care Package

The first 5 pages of the 47-page printable manual, free to keep.



In this sample: What's inside, How to Use This Package, Quick Profile & Cost Overview, Which Hognose This Is, Size & Lifespan. The contents page shows every one of the 47 pages, so you can see exactly what the full package covers before you buy it.

Not in this sample: the 42 pages that follow, which are the full care guide, the health section, the quick reference cards, and the owner tools, checklists and logs.

The full package is \$8.99 at beastlyfacts.com/care-packages/hognose-snake/. One purchase, and every corrected edition is a free re-download from your library. The free hognose snake care guide it was built from is at beastlyfacts.com/guides/hognose-snake/, and stays free.

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What's inside

Every page is written to be used, not just read once.

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START HERE

How to use this package

Three ways to get value from it, depending on where you are right now.

UNITS USED THROUGHOUT

Every temperature and size is given twice. Temperatures appear in degrees Fahrenheit (°F) with degrees Celsius (°C) beside them. Sizes appear in inches (in) and feet (ft), with centimeters (cm) beside them. Snakes and their food are weighed in grams (g), the unit a kitchen scale shows. Humidity is a percentage (%) of how much moisture the air could hold. Prices are in United States dollars.

If you haven't bought a hognose yet

Read the law section first, starting on page 22. In most states a western hognose raises no legal question at all, but in a handful it is banned, capped or permit-only, and in several more the answer depends on which of the three hognose species you buy. Then read pages 4 through 10 before buying any equipment. Two decisions are expensive to get wrong: the enclosure size on page 6, which depends on whether you buy a male or a female, and the heat source on page 8, which has to run through a thermostat, a controller that cuts the heat at a set temperature. The Budget and Shopping List on page 33 then lets you buy once instead of twice.

If your hognose is already home

Start by auditing what you have against the Setup Checklist in the print list below. Then read page 9: this species wants dry air, and an enclosure kept damp is the root of the two most common illnesses in it. If your snake hoods, hisses or rolls over to play dead, page 15 explains why that is normal. If it is refusing food, page 13 comes before any worry. If anything already looks wrong, go straight to Health Red Flags on page 25.

Print these first

- | | |
|--|---|
| ☐ Page 31: Setup Checklist & Targets | ☐ Page 39: Pet-Sitter Sheet |
| ☐ Page 32: Emergency & Quick Targets Card | ☐ Page 40: Owner Log |
| ☐ Page 36: Symptom Quick Reference | ☐ Page 41: Equipment, Quarantine & Vet Log |
| ☐ Page 37: Daily, Weekly & Seasonal Routine | ☐ Page 11: Prey Size & Feeding Schedule |

WHY THIS PACKAGE EXISTS

The western hognose has a reputation built on two things: a theatrical defensive act, and the word "venomous." The act makes owners think a calm snake is an aggressive one, and the word makes owners think a mildly venomous snake is a dangerous one. Neither is true, and both are easier to live with once you know what is going on. The care itself is simple once three things are right: dry air, deep digging substrate (the loose material on the enclosure floor), and feeding an adult less often than a growing juvenile. Every figure here comes from veterinary and scientific sources, listed on page 45, and every temperature and dimension is given in both imperial and metric units.

NOT A SUBSTITUTE FOR

A veterinarian who sees reptiles. This is a husbandry reference for day-to-day care, and anything urgent is a professional call, not a page in this book. Find a reptile vet before you need one, and write the number on the emergency card. Nothing in the law section is legal advice either.

Quick profile

Everything at a glance before you read the detail.

Species covered	The western hognose, <i>Heterodon nasicus</i> , also called the plains hognose. It is the hognose the pet trade sells. The eastern and southern hognoses are different species, and the difference matters for the law.
Native range	The North American plains, from southern Canada to northern Mexico: shortgrass prairie, dry rocky land, and sandy soil it can dig in
Adult size	Females run much larger than males. A typical adult male is 16 to 24 in (41 to 61 cm); a typical adult female 21 to 30 in (53 to 76 cm).
Captive lifespan	10 to 15 years is the usual range, with 15 to 20 reported in captivity
Activity	Active by day, most of all in the morning and late afternoon, and a dedicated burrower
Diet	Toads in the wild. In captivity, frozen-thawed mice, fed every 5 to 7 days while young and about every two weeks as an adult. Page 11
Enclosure, one adult	Male: 20-gallon equivalent, about 30×13×13 in (76×33×33 cm). Female: 40-gallon equivalent, 36×18×16 in (91×46×41 cm). Floor space over height. Page 6
Temperature	Basking 90 to 95°F (32 to 35°C), cool side 70 to 75°F (21 to 24°C), nights at room temperature, no colder than 60°F (16°C). Page 7
Humidity	30 to 50%: dry. One humid hide (a box or cave the snake can get inside) for shedding, and no misting the enclosure. Page 9
Lighting	A 12-hour day. UVB (ultraviolet B, the part of sunlight a reptile's skin uses to make vitamin D3) is not required, but a low-output tube suits this day-active snake.
Substrate	3 to 6 in (8 to 15 cm) of loose, dry, diggable substrate, about 70% soil-based to 30% reptile-safe sand. Page 10
Venom	Rear-fanged and mildly venomous. Not considered dangerous to a healthy person. Page 16
Conservation status	Least Concern, the lowest-risk category on the global Red List of threatened species, but listed as threatened in some states, Illinois among them. Buy captive-bred

Cost overview

Initial setup

The snake is \$50 to \$100 for a normal, wild-type animal (natural color and pattern), and far more for a rare color form. Females typically cost \$50 to \$200 more than males. Itemized, the equipment comes to **\$390 to \$850**, and the enclosure is the biggest single line. With the snake, a first exam and a fecal test (a stool check for parasites), plan on **\$505 to \$1,080**. Page 33 has every line.

Ongoing

Frozen mice, substrate, electricity, two UVB tubes a year if you run one, and a yearly wellness exam come to **\$235 to \$390 a year**, about \$15 to \$35 a month. A respiratory infection or an impaction can run into the hundreds to treat, and an X-ray image, called a radiograph, is \$100 to \$250 a view.

THE NUMBER THAT SHOULD DRIVE THE DECISION

Not the price. The lifespan. A hognose bought for a ten-year-old can still be in the house when that child leaves for college, and some live to 20. The purchase is the cheap part. The routine on page 37, and a reptile vet for every one of those years, is what you are signing up for.

Which hognose this is, size & lifespan

"Hognose" is a common name shared by several species. The law and the care both depend on which one you have.

Three hognose species live in the United States, and a fourth, the Mexican hognose, reaches into the southwest. The one sold as a pet is almost always the **western hognose, *Heterodon nasicus***, which some state laws call the plains hog-nosed snake. Its smaller size, milder bluffing and flexible diet made it the hognose most keepers settled on, and most animals sold now are captive-bred rather than collected. This package is written for the western hognose only.

SPECIES	WHERE IT FITS	WHY IT MATTERS TO YOU
Western (plains) hognose <i>Heterodon nasicus</i>	The pet-trade species. Dry prairie and sandy ground	Every figure in this package. Several state laws name it directly, some to allow it and some to restrict it
Eastern hognose <i>Heterodon platirhinos</i>	Native across much of the eastern half of the country. Its care differs: more humidity and a cooler basking spot than the western	Protected or restricted as a native species in many states that leave the western alone. Never collect one from the wild
Southern hognose <i>Heterodon simus</i>	A southeastern native	Protected by name in Alabama, and on Georgia's list of natives that may not be kept as pets

GET THE SPECIES IN WRITING

State rules are written to the scientific name, and the common names overlap: "plains hognose" and "western hognose" are the same snake. Ask for a receipt that names *Heterodon nasicus* and says captive-bred. In several states that one line is the difference between a legal pet and a prohibited one. Pages 22 to 24.

How big, and how heavy

STAGE	LENGTH	WEIGHT
Hatchling	5.5 to 7 in (14 to 18 cm)	Usually 4 to 7 g. Under 3 g happens, and 13 to 14 g is a record
Adult male	Typically 16 to 24 in (41 to 61 cm), many around 20 in (51 cm). Over 25 in (64 cm) is unusual	Small. Adult males are commonly fed as 40 to 70 g snakes
Adult female	Typically 21 to 30 in (53 to 76 cm)	150 to 200 g in a young adult, 220 to 400 g in an older one

Published ranges vary. Another range is 14 to 37 in (36 to 93 cm), averaging about 20 in (50 cm), at 80 to 350 g, and across the hognose species as a group the range runs 1.5 to 3.5 ft (45 to 107 cm). The weights in the table are a guide, not a target: your own snake's weight trend matters more.

How long it lives

10 to 15 years is the usual captive range, and **15 to 20** is reported in captivity. In the wild, a western hognose lives about 14 years on average, with a reported range of 9 to 19.

The animal behind the care

The upturned snout is a digging tool. The enlarged scale at its tip, the rostral scale, is shovel-shaped, and the snake uses it to burrow through loose soil after buried toads, its main wild prey. Toads can make up nearly 80% of the diet in some regions. In the wild it spends roughly September to March below ground. Every part of the captive setup follows from that life: dry air, deep loose substrate, and a snake that may slow down in winter.